FACTSHEET 5 • USING GRAPHS AND TABLES

Anatomy of a table people can actually read

A good table answers a question. A bad table makes the reader do your work for you.

The one-sentence test

Before you build any table, finish this sentence:

"This table shows the reader that …" — If you cannot finish it in one sentence, you do not yet know what the table is for, and you are not ready to build it.

The eight parts of a self-explanatory table

#	Part	What it must do
1	**Table number and title**	Say *what*, *who*, *where* and *when*. "Table 2. Treatment outcomes among TB patients registered in eight municipalities, Timor-Leste, 2024" — not "Table 2. Results".
2	**Total N in the title or header**	Write (N = 180) so the reader never has to add up your column.
3	**Row labels in a sensible order**	Order by frequency, or by natural order (age groups), or by the order you will discuss them. Never alphabetical unless alphabetical *is* the logic.
4	**n and % together**	Give both: "96 (53.3)". The count lets the reader check you; the percentage lets them compare.
5	**Consistent decimal places**	One decimal place for percentages is almost always right. "78.75%" claims a precision your data does not have.
6	**Column headers that name the denominator**	"n (%) of 160 evaluated" beats "n (%)" every time.
7	**A footnote for every exclusion**	"*20 patients excluded: 8 still on treatment, 12 transferred out." This is where honesty lives.
8	**No vertical lines, minimal horizontal lines**	Three horizontal rules — above the header, below the header, below the table. That is the standard for every medical journal.

A table before and after

Before — what most first drafts look like

Outcome	Number	Percent
Cured	96	53.33333
Treatment completed	30	16.66667
Died	14	7.777778
Lost to follow up	16	8.888889
Failed	4	2.222222
Not evaluated	12	6.666667
	180	100

Problems: no title, no denominator stated, absurd decimals, the 8 patients still on treatment have vanished without explanation, and the reader has no idea what question this answers.

After — publishable

Table 2. Treatment outcomes among patients registered for TB treatment in eight municipalities, Timor-Leste, 2024 (N = 180)

Treatment outcome	n (%)
Cured	96 (53.3)
Treatment completed	30 (16.7)
Treatment success (cured + completed)	**126 (70.0)**
Died	14 (7.8)
Lost to follow-up	16 (8.9)
Treatment failed	4 (2.2)
Not evaluated (transferred out)	12 (6.7)
Still on treatment at time of analysis	8 (4.4)
Total	**180 (100.0)**

Percentages are of all 180 patients registered. Treatment success using the WHO evaluated cohort (excluding 12 not evaluated and 8 still on treatment) was 126/160 (78.8%).

> **TIP**
>
> Notice what the good table does: it **accounts for all 180 patients**, it gives the success rate under *both* denominators in a footnote, and the reader can reconstruct every number. Nothing is hidden.

Liafuan importante • Key words in Tetum

Table	**Tabela**
Title	**Títulu**
Row	**Liña**
Column	**Koluna**
Total	**Totál**
Note, footnote	**Nota**